

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 162

By Oliver

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend the memory of Dr.
Charles Edward Dudley, Sr., for his outstanding
spiritual leadership in the Seventh-day Adventist
Church.

WHEREAS, it is the pleasure of the members of this General Assembly to acknowledge the memory of those venerable men and women who were willing to dedicate their lives to ensure the individual and collective freedom of oppressed groups across the nation; and

WHEREAS, one such distinguished individual is Dr. Charles Edward Dudley, Sr., a civil rights activist, Seventh-day Adventist conference leader, and minister; and

WHEREAS, born on February 1, 1927, in South Bend, Indiana, Dr. Dudley was the grandson of some of the formerly enslaved founders of the Thomas Chapel Methodist Episcopal Church in Hickman, Kentucky, an inspiring mantle that Dr. Dudley would gracefully carry on in his ministerial endeavors and pursuit of racial justice; and

WHEREAS, the youngest of Joseph and Julia Dudley's seven children, Dr. Dudley spent his childhood in South Bend before transferring to complete high school at Oakwood Academy in Huntsville, Alabama, and he followed the Oakwood track to Oakwood College, where he graduated with a Bachelor of Ministry and met his wife, Etta Mae Maycock; and

WHEREAS, his first nineteen years of service in the Seventh-day Adventist Church concentrated on ministry in numerous states throughout the South, pastoring communities wherever he was called, and in 1962, he became the president of the South Central Conference, which oversees the missional needs of African-American communities in Alabama, Kentucky, Louisiana, Mississippi, Tennessee, the northeast sections of Arkansas, and the panhandle of Florida; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Dudley's time as president, which spanned an unprecedented thirty-one years, saw striking growth in membership, from 4,300 to 23,000 members; the construction of approximately 100 new church and school structures; and the acquisition of government support through the Housing and Urban Development Act for seven federally subsidized housing complexes for the underprivileged and elderly, including in Nashville and Clarksville; and

WHEREAS, he deftly balanced his righteous indignation at the evil of racial inequality with his diplomatic skill and tact to achieve institutional progress for his flock amid the tumultuous times of the Civil Rights movement in the South; and

WHEREAS, cognizant of the unique challenges facing the Black Adventist community, Dr. Dudley was indispensable to the creation of unions between other Black conferences in the North American Division of the Seventh-day Adventist Church; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Dudley was convinced of the greater efficacy of local bodies in producing real change, and he refused consideration for higher offices in order to continue his work at the regional level; and

WHEREAS, a man of myriad talents, Dr. Dudley was a gifted vocalist and journalist, and he utilized the latter skill to write several studies in his retirement; and

WHEREAS, he maintained a great love and support for education, and he rendered extended service as vice chairman of the Oakwood College Board of Trustees, a tenure that saw the school's enrollment more than triple, growing from approximately 400 to over 1,400 students; and

WHEREAS, apart from his work in ministry and leadership, Dr. Dudley was also deeply devoted to his family, especially his three children, Bonita, Charles II, and Albert; despite his many and great responsibilities, he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Charles Dudley truly embodies the volunteer spirit, and he has done much to contribute to the well-being of his fellow citizens in various capacities; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Dudley was a public-spirited citizen of the highest order and most worthy of our approbation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend the memory of Dr. Charles Edward Dudley, Sr., for his manifold contributions to his fellow citizens, graciously remembering his life's incalculable effect upon the cause of justice and right in our State and elsewhere.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.